How Much of LEV's Error Is the Catalogue's? An Empirical Evaluation of NIST's Likely Exploited Vulnerabilities Metric

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Abstract

NIST's Cybersecurity White Paper 41 proposed Likely Exploited Vulnerabilities (LEV), a probability that a CVE has already been exploited, computed by compounding a CVE's history of EPSS scores. The white paper proposed using LEV to find exploited vulnerabilities missing from CISA's Known Exploited Vulnerabilities (KEV) catalogue, and noted that measuring its performance would need outside data. We report what we believe is the first empirical evaluation of LEV. We reimplement the metric, reproduce all four average-LEV values the white paper publishes to within 11%, and test its calibration on 105,250 CVEs. Against KEV, LEV over-predicts by 17.3x. Most of that gap has causes other than LEV's core logic. EPSS was retrained during the observation window, and one retraining tripled cohort scores overnight; 26.9% of LEV's probability mass is this version artifact. LEV also grows without saturating as the analysis date advances, contrary to the white paper's premise that EPSS decays for old CVEs. To separate LEV's error from KEV's incompleteness we estimate, with capture-recapture methods over four exploitation lists, how much exploitation no list recorded. Two lists that appear independent of KEV turn out to contain all of it, and a third contains the whole of a fourth. Once those overlaps are removed, counting alone attributes about two-thirds of the KEV-measured over-prediction to catalogue incompleteness. Against model-based estimates of true exploitation, LEV over-predicts by about 2-2.5x wherever the estimate is identified. A monotone correction fitted one year earlier transfers exactly to unseen CVEs against the broader ground truth, but drifts against KEV and across birth cohorts, because the same LEV means different things at different CVE ages.

1 Introduction

Defenders cannot patch everything, so they rank. Two public resources dominate that ranking. The Exploit Prediction Scoring System (EPSS) gives each CVE a daily probability of exploitation in the next 30 days [2, 3]. CISA's Known Exploited Vulnerabilities catalogue (KEV) lists CVEs with confirmed exploitation [4]. EPSS looks forward and KEV looks back; neither says how likely it is that a given CVE has *already* been exploited without anyone recording it.

Mell and Spring proposed LEV to fill that gap [1]. LEV treats each 30-day EPSS score as the probability of exploitation in that window and combines the windows since the CVE first appeared:

$$\mathrm{LEV}(v, d_0, d_n) = 1 - \prod_i \left(1 - \mathrm{epss}(v, d_i) \cdot w(d_i, d_n)\right),$$

where $d_i = d_0 + 30i$ and w is 1 for full windows and the remaining fraction for the last one. The white paper suggests two uses: flagging high-LEV CVEs absent from KEV as likely exploited, and measuring how complete KEV is. It also states that assessing LEV's performance requires collaboration with parties holding exploitation data [1]. We found no published evaluation (Section 8).

The obvious evaluation compares LEV with KEV. It cannot separate two stories. If LEV says 0.99 and the CVE is not in KEV, either LEV is wrong or KEV missed it, and the second story is the one the white paper proposes LEV for. A KEV-only evaluation therefore measures LEV's error and KEV's blindness together, in unknown proportion.

We address this in two phases. Phase 1 evaluates LEV against KEV and takes the measured gap apart into causes we can observe directly in EPSS data. Phase 2 adds independent exploitation lists and estimates, with capture-recapture methods from epidemiology and human-rights statistics, the exploitation none of them recorded. That estimate is what lets LEV's error be separated from KEV's.

Our contributions:

1. **Reproduction and calibration.** We reimplement LEV, reproduce the white paper's four published average-LEV values to within 11%, and show that against KEV it over-predicts by 17.3x while still ranking CVEs into three distinguishable levels.
2. **EPSS version drift.** EPSS was retrained inside the observation window. Model version strings are build dates, not deployment dates; located by day, one retraining multiplied cohort scores 3.06x overnight. LEV compounds across such boundaries, and 26.9% of its probability mass is this artifact.
3. **No saturation.** For fixed cohorts LEV grows convexly with the analysis date and shows no sign of levelling off. Cohort EPSS rises rather than decays, contrary to the white paper's premise.
4. **Catalogue incompleteness, estimated.** We audit every candidate exploitation list for dependence before use. Two that look independent of KEV contain all of it, and VulnCheck's KEV contains the whole of the Shadowserver honeypot list. With the dependence removed, counting alone attributes about two-thirds of the KEV-measured gap to catalogue incompleteness, and log-linear capture-recapture models put LEV's own over-prediction at about 2-2.5x.
5. **A validated correction.** We fit a monotone map from LEV to observed exploitation and validate it prospectively on CVEs it never saw. Against the broader ground truth it transfers exactly a year ahead; against KEV, and across birth cohorts, it drifts, which exposes a further property of LEV: its meaning depends on CVE age.

All data snapshots, hashes and code are released, and one command regenerates every number in this paper (Section 10).

2 Background

2.1 EPSS

EPSS is a gradient-boosted model that scores every published CVE daily with the probability of exploitation activity in the following 30 days [2, 3]. Its ground-truth labels come from intrusion-detection and honeypot telemetry supplied by Fortinet, AlienVault OTX, the Shadowserver Foundation and GreyNoise [3]. The v3 model's 1,477 input features include public exploit code (Exploit-DB, GitHub, Metasploit), offensive tool templates (Nuclei and others), and membership of public exploitation lists, among them CISA KEV [3]. Two facts about this matter later. KEV is an *input* to EPSS, so a CVE's KEV listing can raise its later EPSS scores. And the model is retrained periodically, which can move every score in the corpus at once.

2.2 LEV

LEV is the equation in Section 1, applied from the CVE's first EPSS date d_0 to an analysis date d_n. Each 30-day window takes the EPSS score on its first day. The white paper also defines LEV2, which uses every daily score with each converted to a one-day probability. Because LEV is a product over windows it cannot decrease as d_n advances. The white paper argues the growth should stall because EPSS scores for old, unexploited CVEs decay toward zero [1].

2.3 KEV

CISA maintains KEV under Binding Operational Directive 22-01 [4]. An entry requires reliable evidence of exploitation, an assigned CVE and clear remediation guidance. `dateAdded` records when CISA catalogued the CVE, not when exploitation began. KEV is selective by design: it serves federal remediation priorities rather than aiming at complete coverage.

3 Data

EPSS. We use 67 monthly snapshots (the first of each month, plus the dates Table 5 of [1] anchors on) from 2021-04-14 to 2026-08-01: 14,456,555 scores for 367,311 CVEs. A further 171 daily files serve two checks: they locate retraining dates, and they bound the error from monthly sampling (Section 7).

CISA KEV. catalogVersion 2026.08.25, 1,676 entries. 1,665 have EPSS data; the other 11 were never scored and cannot receive a LEV value.

CVE List v5. Release `cve_2026-08-25_1700Z`, 192,054 records from 2022 onward, for CVSS, CWE and vendor.

Exploitation lists for Phase 2. The CIRCL Vulnerability-Lookup service publishes "exploited" sightings with the source of each [5]; we retrieved all 68,191 on 2026-09-28. VulnCheck's KEV [11] lists 5,371 records, each with the URL and date of every exploitation report behind it; we retrieved it with a community token on the same day. We also retrieved ENISA's EU Vulnerability Database known-exploited dump [6]. Section 4.6 describes how each became, or did not become, a list.

Analysis population. Unless stated otherwise, LEV is computed at d_n = 2026-08-01. The calibration cohort is the 105,250 CVEs first scored in the EPSS v3 era (from 2023-03-07), at least six months before d_n so each had time to reach KEV. We exclude CVEs that EPSS backfilled: when EPSS v2 launched on 2022-02-04 its coverage jumped from 80,800 to 168,325 CVEs, most of them old, and taking first-EPSS date as a publication proxy would count them as new. A CVE is kept only if EPSS first scored it within one calendar year of its CVE-ID year. 495 cohort CVEs are in KEV, a base rate of 0.47%.

Provenance. Every fixed file is recorded with its SHA-256. Sources served from moving branches or live APIs (Exploit-DB, Metasploit, CIRCL, EUVD) are snapshotted and committed with the code rather than re-fetched.

4 Methods

4.1 Reimplementation and reproduction

We implement LEV and LEV2 as specified, including the white paper's inclusive day count for the final partial window and LEV2's division of each daily score by 30. When a window starts on a date we do not hold, we take the next available snapshot, the rule the white paper gives for its own code [1, Sec. 10.3]. We compare the average LEV of CVEs published since each date in Table 5 of [1] with the published values, at d_n = 2025-03-01, close to the white paper's own analysis date, which it does not state. LEV grows with d_n, so the date matters: at d_n = 2026-08-01 the first row overshoots by 297%.

4.2 Calibration

We bin the cohort into ten LEV buckets and compare each bucket's mean LEV with the fraction of its CVEs in KEV, with Wilson score intervals [7] for the observed rates. Adjacent buckets are compared with Fisher's exact test under Holm correction [8]. We report the Brier score [9] and expected calibration error (ECE) over the same ten bins [10].

4.3 Version normalization

To remove score shifts caused by EPSS retraining, we map every score produced after the 2025-03-17 retraining back onto the preceding model's scale. Each score keeps its percentile within its own day's file, and we substitute the score at that percentile in the last pre-retraining file (2025-03-16). This removes corpus-wide shifts. It cannot separate them from genuine per-CVE improvement in the newer model, so normalized LEV is a lower bound on a correction, not a corrected value.

4.4 Analysis-date sweep

For two fixed cohorts (13,685 CVEs first scored March-September 2023, and 7,558 first scored May-September 2021) we compute LEV at every month from 2023-10-01 to 2026-08-01 and fit six growth families: linear, logarithmic, saturating, quadratic, exponential and power law. We compare them by AIC over the full sweep and within the longest stretch with no retraining.

4.5 Circularity

Because KEV is an EPSS input, we test how much listing moves scores, with two designs that cannot select on the outcome. First, for each KEV CVE we compare EPSS in the last snapshot before `dateAdded` with the first snapshot on or after it, net of non-KEV CVEs in the same starting-score decile over the same pair of snapshots. Pairs that straddle a retraining are excluded. Second, we compute each KEV member's LEV using only scores dated before its listing, which the listing cannot have influenced.

4.6 Capture-recapture

Lists. An exploitation list is a set of CVEs a source records as exploited in the wild. We use four:

- CISA: CISA KEV.
- SENSOR: CIRCL sightings from Shadowserver's honeypot feed (969 CVEs), which records attempted exploitation directly.
- VULNCHK: VulnCheck's KEV rebuilt from its per-report evidence (4,815 CVEs).
- SOCIAL: CIRCL sightings from Telegram and similar channels (2,396 CVEs).

We audited every candidate for dependence before use, because a list that contains another makes their overlap equal to the smaller one by construction. Three such cases turned up. CIRCL's aggregated KEV catalogue contains all 1,676 CISA KEV CVEs; we exclude it. VulnCheck's KEV includes CISA KEV by its own documentation, so we rebuild it from its reports and drop every report hosted on cisa.gov. The third was less obvious. VulnCheck's largest single source is Shadowserver's dashboard (401,967 reports), and every one of the 969 SENSOR CVEs appears in VulnCheck's Shadowserver subset, so we drop those reports too. What remains is VulnCheck's own honeypot canaries, SANS DShield, CrowdSec, vendor advisories and threat reports. For 78% of CISA-listed CVEs the earliest remaining report predates CISA's listing (median 28 days), so the remainder is not an echo of CISA.

EU KEV lists 66 CVEs; 55 are also on CISA KEV, and 36 of the 41 in our KEV snapshot (88%) carry CISA's own date, so we treat it as derivative. ENISA's exploited-flag search returns the same consolidated set. Exploit-DB records exploit availability, not exploitation, and is excluded.

Primary lists. Telegram channels carry mass lists of CVEs that actors claim to use. Before VulnCheck was available we had already excluded the lowest LEV stratum for this reason, since its single-list captures were 86% Telegram-only. With four lists we therefore take CISA, SENSOR and VULNCHK, the three whose entries each cite evidence, as primary, and report every other configuration alongside.

Population. SENSOR begins on 2024-10-24. We restrict to the 54,612 CVEs first scored between 2024-10-24 and 2026-01-30, so every list could observe every CVE from its first score, and apply the six-month maturity rule. 734 of these appear on at least one of the primary lists.

Models. Two-list estimates among all four lists disagree by 2.4x (530 to 1,256), so the lists are not independent and dependence has to be modelled. We fit Poisson log-linear models to the seven observable capture patterns under every hierarchical structure of two-way interactions, assume no three-way interaction (the standard identifying assumption [12, 13]), select by AIC, and bootstrap a 95% interval from the fitted cell means (1,000 replicates; other seeds, or 10,000 replicates, move the endpoints by at most 0.06). Chao's estimator [14], a lower bound that stays valid under heterogeneous capture probabilities, is reported alongside.

When not to report an estimate. Log-linear estimates of the unseen cell can be driven entirely by the choice of interaction terms. We declare a population not identified, and report no point estimate, if models within 2 AIC of the best disagree by more than 2x [15], if the estimate exceeds the population, or if it falls below the lower end of Chao's interval. For a population pooled over LEV strata the last rule uses the sum of the per-stratum Chao bounds, since pooling hides the heterogeneity that stratification absorbs.

The truth ladder. Rather than one estimate, we report LEV's over-confidence (mean LEV over the exploitation rate) against successively stronger notions of truth, each adding one assumption: KEV alone; KEV or SENSOR; the union of the primary lists; Chao's bound; the log-linear estimate. Every rung is a lower bound on, or an estimate of, the number exploited, so every over-confidence figure is an upper bound on LEV's error. A reader can stop at whichever assumption they accept.

4.7 Correction curve

We fit a monotone map from LEV to observed exploitation by isotonic regression [16] and by Platt scaling [17], and a Platt variant that also takes log CVE age. There are two targets: KEV on the calibration cohort, and the union of the primary lists on the Phase 2 population. All scores are on held-

out CVEs, under three schemes. Five-fold cross-validation is the in-distribution case. A split by first-score date trains on older CVEs and tests on newer ones. The deciding scheme is prospective: the map is fitted at d_n = 2025-08-01 with outcomes known then, and applied at 2026-08-01 to the 44,316 CVEs first scored after the training cohort, none of which it saw.

5 Results

5.1 The reimplementation reproduces the white paper

CVEs published since	CSWP 41	ours	difference
2023-03-07	0.015	0.0162	+8%
2022-02-04	0.047	0.0480	+2%
2021-04-14	0.087	0.0839	-4%
all CVEs	0.146	0.1299	-11%

Table 1: Average LEV at d_n = 2025-03-01 against Table 5 of [1].

All four values fall within 11%. The fourth row matches only with the backfill correction of Section 3; without it we get 0.255 (+75%). This validates the implementation. It does not validate the metric, and the agreement is specific to the analysis date.

5.2 Against KEV, LEV over-predicts 17.3x but ranks

Across the 105,250-CVE cohort, mean LEV is 0.081 against a KEV rate of 0.0047: LEV over-predicts by 17.3x (95% interval 15.8-18.9x from Poisson error on the 495 KEV CVEs; Brier 0.0373, ECE 0.0765). The observed rate climbs from 0.03% in the lowest LEV bucket to 12.9% in the highest, where LEV averages 0.987 (Figure 1). Only two of the nine adjacent-bucket differences survive Holm correction, those at either end. LEV separates three levels (low, middle, high) rather than ten.

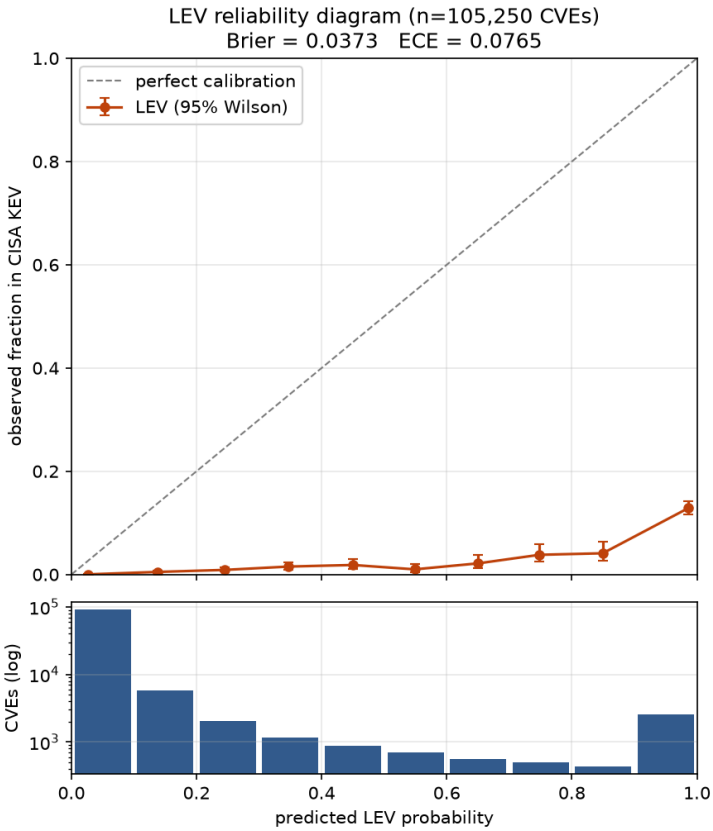


Figure 1. Reliability of LEV against CISA KEV. Error bars are 95% Wilson intervals.

5.3 EPSS retraining puts an artifact into LEV

EPSS's model version strings are build dates. Version v2025.03.14 first appears in the file for 2025-03-17. On an unchanged set of 13,552 CVEs, cohort mean EPSS goes from 0.00862 on 2025-03-16 to 0.02640 the next day, a 3.06x step (Figure 2). Anyone bracketing by the version string measures almost no change. Of the rise in cohort EPSS over 2023-2026, 64% (v3 cohort) and 70% (v1/v2 cohort) happens at retraining boundaries rather than between them.

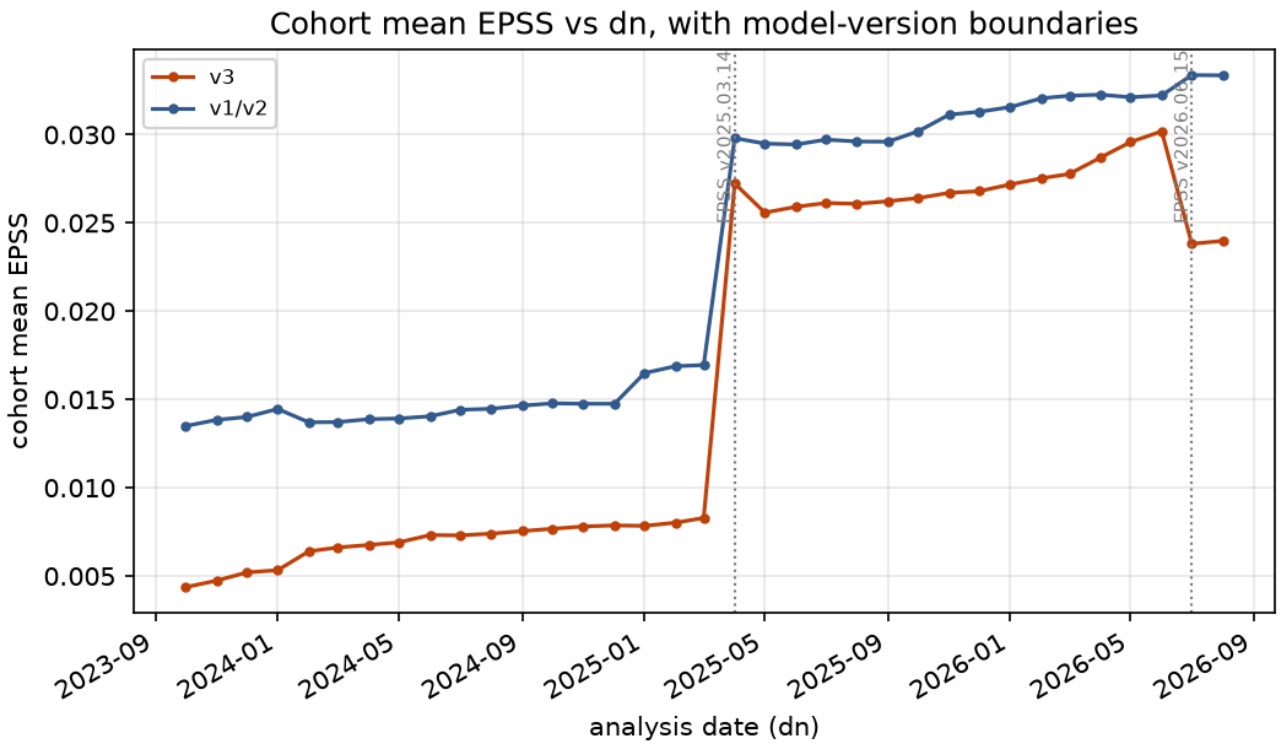


Figure 2. Cohort mean EPSS, with model-version boundaries.

LEV multiplies scores across these boundaries as if they belonged to one measurement series. When post-retraining scores are mapped back to the v3 scale (Section 4.3), mean LEV drops by 26.9%, and over-prediction against KEV falls from 17.3x to 12.6x (Brier 0.0289, ECE 0.0547). Version mixing accounts for part of the gap but leaves most of it. Normalization also moves three of the four CSWP 41 Table 5 values toward the published figures at d_n = 2026-08-01 (mean absolute deviation 102% to 63%), without ever seeing them; the fourth, which spans pre-v3 models, moves away.

5.4 LEV grows without saturating

For the 2023 cohort, mean LEV rises from 0.008 to 0.135 between October 2023 and August 2026 (Figure 3). A quadratic fits better than linear, logarithmic or saturating growth, both over the full sweep and within the retraining-free stretch (AIC margin 13.2 over linear there), and the preference survives version normalization. Monthly increments grow rather than shrink. The premise behind the expected slowdown fails as well: cohort mean EPSS rises from 0.0044 to 0.0240 rather than decaying. If this continues, the share of the cohort above LEV 0.9 roughly doubles by 2028, and LEV loses discrimination as more of the corpus approaches 1.

Monotone growth is a property of the equation, not a finding. The empirical content is the shape: no saturation within 34 months, and no evidence of the decay the white paper relies on.

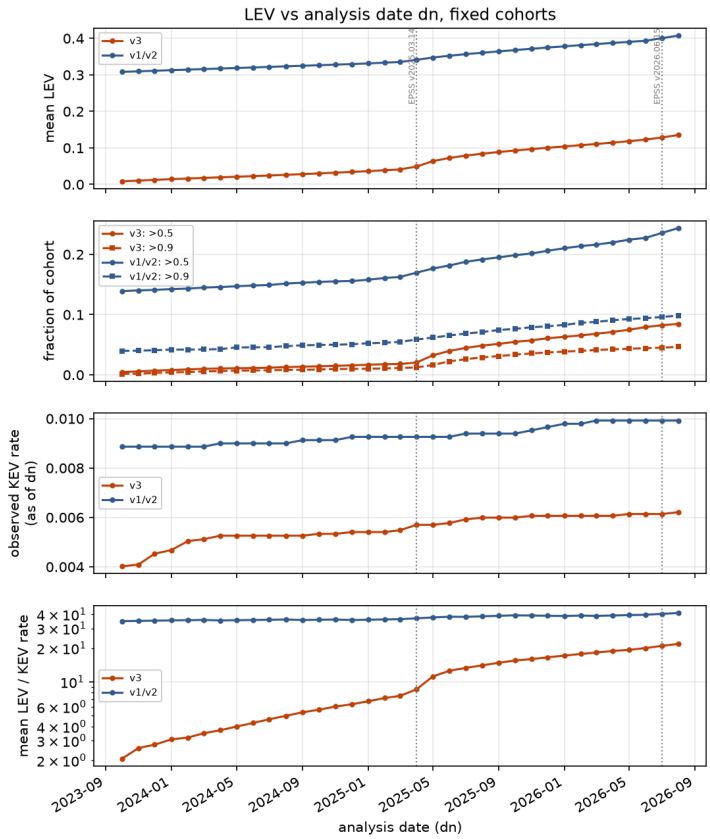


Figure 3. LEV for fixed cohorts as the analysis date advances. Dotted lines mark retrainings.

5.5 High LEV mostly follows KEV listing

At the listing date, the median KEV CVE's EPSS does not move relative to matched non-KEV controls, but a quarter of listed CVEs rise at least 2.85x more than their controls. The KEV input feature matters for a sizeable minority of listings rather than all of them.

The second test bears on the white paper's proposed use. 56% of cohort KEV members were listed in the same month EPSS first scored them, so LEV could not have flagged them first. Of the 220 with a pre-listing history (a median of 2.8 months), 15% had LEV >= 0.5 before CISA listed them, and the median was 0.006; after listing the median is 1.0. Part of that gap is elapsed time, since pre-listing LEV covers fewer windows. Either way, among the CVEs KEV did list, high LEV mostly arrived after the listing. This tells against using LEV as a leading indicator of KEV listing, and it means the high-LEV bucket's KEV concentration in Section 5.2 is partly circular.

5.6 How much of the gap is the catalogue's

Table 2 gives the truth ladder on the 54,612-CVE Phase 2 population with the three primary lists. Against KEV alone, LEV over-predicts by 7.93x.

truth	assumption added	exploited	over-confidence
CISA KEV	KEV is complete	236	7.93x [6.98, 9.05]
CISA or SENSOR	honeypot sightings are real	336	5.57x [5.01, 6.22]
union of primary lists	every listed report is real	734	2.55x [2.37, 2.75]
Chao lower bound	closed population	1,094	1.71x [1.57, 1.84]
log-linear	no three-way interaction	not identified	

Table 2: LEV over-confidence against successively stronger notions of truth, all LEV strata pooled. Intervals are 95%: Poisson on the counts, log-normal for Chao.

By counting alone, over-prediction falls from 7.93x to 2.55x, so about two-thirds (68%, 95% interval 64-71%) of the gap measured against KEV is catalogue incompleteness. KEV recorded at most a third (32%) of the exploited CVEs that any primary list observed, and at most 22% under Chao's bound. The pooled log-linear estimate falls below Chao's bound and is not reported. Table 3 stratifies by LEV.

LEV	N	vs KEV	union	Chao	log-linear
[0.0, 0.1)	52,012	21.2x	2.36x	0.83x	not identified
[0.1, 0.9)	1,964	9.16x	3.21x	2.30x	2.47x [1.92, 3.08]
[0.9, 1.0]	636	4.54x	2.26x	1.96x	2.04x [1.81, 2.32]

Table 3: Over-confidence by LEV stratum, primary lists.

In the two upper strata, which together carry about two-thirds of LEV's probability mass, LEV over-predicts estimated true exploitation by about 2x and 2.5x. At the top, LEV averages 0.985 and we estimate 48% [42%, 54%] of those CVEs were exploited. The lowest stratum holds 95% of the CVEs and is not identified: the model estimate falls below Chao's bound there.

Does this hinge on the choice of lists? Table 4 repeats the estimate under every configuration.

lists	LEV [0.9, 1.0]	LEV [0.1, 0.9)	all LEV
CISA, SENSOR, VULNCHK (primary)	2.04x [1.81, 2.32]	2.47x [1.92, 3.08]	not identified
CISA, SENSOR, strict VULNCHK	2.12x [1.85, 2.42]	not identified	not identified
CISA, SENSOR, SOCIAL	2.07x [1.73, 2.43]	not identified	not claimed (0.99x)
all four	1.54x [0.70, 2.02]	not identified	not claimed (0.35x)
CISA, SOCIAL, VULNCHK (no SENSOR)	not identified	not identified	not identified

Table 4: Log-linear over-confidence by list configuration. "Not claimed": identified by our rules but pooled over strata the stratified analysis rejects.

The top-stratum estimate is about 2x in every configuration built from evidence-citing lists, and also in the original three-list set. It drops to 1.54x, with an interval that includes calibration, only when Telegram sightings enter a four-list model. The strict configuration keeps a VulnCheck CVE only if a sensor saw it or at least two independent sources reported it (2,912 CVEs). It matters because VulnCheck now supplies 84-99% of the CVEs seen by a single list, and 65% of the VulnCheck-only CVEs rest on one text report. Under the strict list the top stratum still gives 2.12x. The pooled strict estimate (2.64x) falls below the sum of the per-stratum Chao bounds (709 against 721 exploited CVEs), so it is not identified. The middle stratum does not survive the strict check. Its 2.47x depends on VulnCheck's single-report entries, and under the strict list Chao's bound caps it at 3.21x.

Two further checks. Shadowserver is one of EPSS's label sources, so EPSS is trained to predict roughly what SENSOR records. Without SENSOR nothing is identified, but counting still gives 2.10x pooled and 2.25x at the top, in line with the primary result. And the listing boost of Section 5.5 lifts

some KEV members into the top stratum. They are true positives, so without the boost the top stratum's exploited share would likely be lower, and the 2x figure is probably conservative.

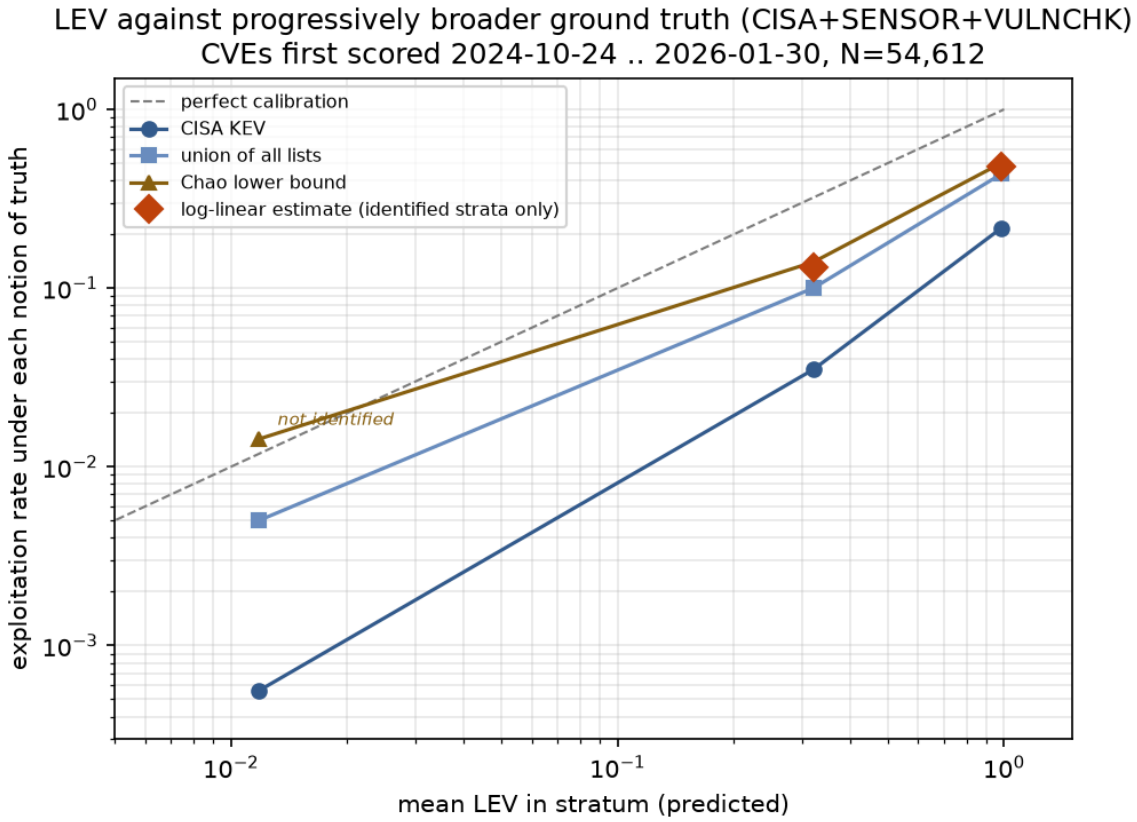


Figure 4. LEV against progressively broader ground truth, by LEV stratum, primary lists.

5.7 A correction curve, and why it drifts

method	Brier	ECE	predicted / observed
raw LEV	0.0113	0.0230	6.30x
isotonic	0.0036	0.0020	0.61x
Platt	0.0037	0.0015	0.66x
Platt with CVE age	0.0036	0.0014	0.72x

Table 5: Prospective validation against KEV. Fitted at 2025-08-01; scored at 2026-08-01 on 44,316 CVEs the fit never saw.

Under cross-validation any of the three maps restores calibration (predicted over observed 1.00-1.01x). Prospectively against KEV, each cuts calibration error 11-17x, but all under-predict by 28-39% a year later. Against the union of the primary lists, isotonic regression transfers exactly (1.00x; ECE 0.0138 to 0.0046; Figure 5), although that fit rests on only 111 positives. Much of the KEV-target drift therefore reflects KEV's narrow and lagging coverage rather than the correction itself. Transfer across birth cohorts is worse: a map fitted on CVEs first scored before 2025-06-01 under-predicts the younger ones at the same analysis date (isotonic 0.30x, Platt 0.52x against the union), and the age-aware Platt model overshoots (2.32x).

The drift has a cause we can name. An old CVE reaches a given LEV through many windows of modest EPSS, and a new one through a few high scores. The second is stronger evidence, so the same LEV value carries a different probability at different ages. A Platt model that also takes log

age recovers about a quarter of the drift. This is the non-saturation of Section 5.4 seen from another side: LEV's scale depends on how long it has been accumulating.

LEV	corrected to KEV	corrected to union of primary lists
0.10	0.8% [0.5, 1.0]	6.1% [4.6, 7.5]
0.50	2.7% [1.9, 4.1]	15.5% [11.5, 19.0]
0.90	6.7% [4.4, 8.4]	20.2% [16.5, 29.5]
0.99	8.2% [6.4, 10.1]	32.5% [26.9, 37.4]
1.00	27.8% [24.3, 30.9]	76.3% [68.0, 85.9]

Table 6: The isotonic correction, fitted on all data, with 95% bootstrap intervals (400 resamples of CVEs). Both targets are catalogue appearance and so are lower bounds on true exploitation. The intervals are several points wide: the curve gives the scale of LEV's error, not a precise mapping for a single score.

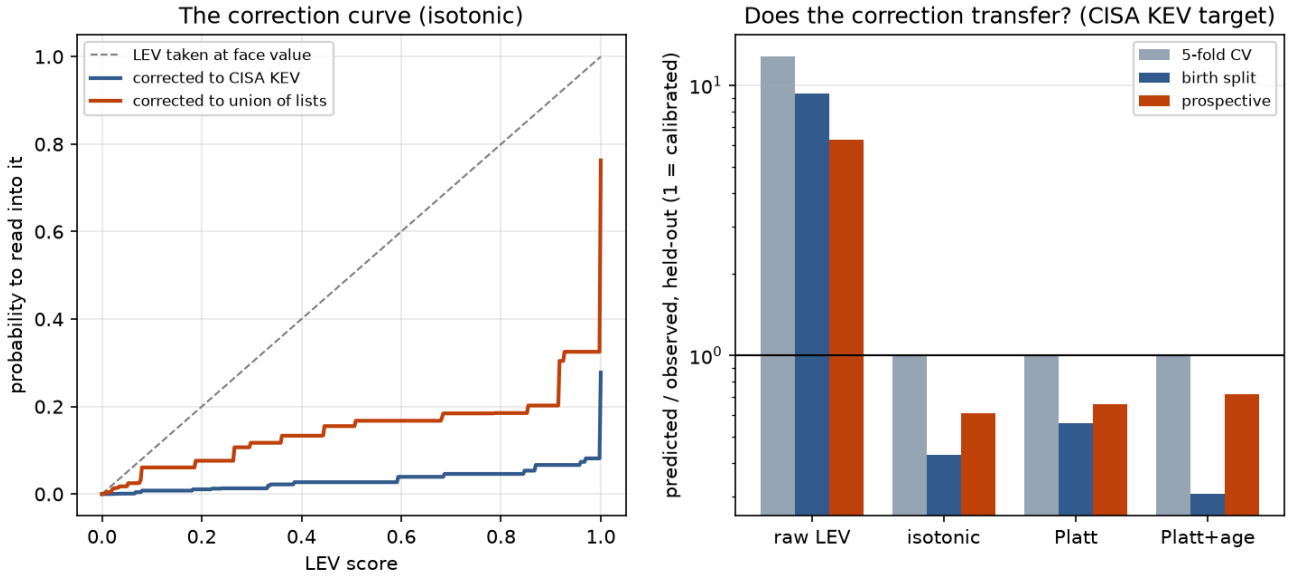


Figure 5. Left: the correction curves. Right: held-out predicted/observed under each validation scheme.

6 Discussion

What LEV is good for. LEV ranks. Its extremes separate: the top bucket's KEV rate is nearly 500 times the bottom bucket's. Its values should not be read as probabilities. A LEV of 0.9 corresponds to about 7% chance of KEV listing and about 20% chance of appearing on any of our primary lists.

What LEV is not good for yet. The white paper proposes LEV for finding exploited CVEs that KEV misses. Our results cut both ways on that. LEV's apparent over-confidence is substantially KEV's incompleteness, which is the premise of the proposal. But among CVEs KEV did list, high LEV mostly came after the listing, so LEV did not anticipate them.

What would make LEV more reliable. Four changes follow from the results. Compute LEV within a single EPSS model version, or normalize across versions, since retraining otherwise enters as evidence. State the analysis date with every published LEV value, since values are not comparable across dates. Stop accumulating, or decay, windows for CVEs with no recent evidence, or accept that LEV drifts toward 1. And validate against more than KEV: KEV is both an EPSS input and incomplete.

KEV coverage. Empirical Security reports that KEV covers at most about 8.7% of CVEs with observed exploitation activity, from proprietary telemetry [18]. Our figures come from open data on a younger population: KEV recorded at most 32% of what our primary lists observed, and at most 22% under Chao's bound. The direction agrees. The levels differ as they should, since four lists see less than one vendor's full telemetry.

Two definitions of "exploited." Part of the KEV gap is definitional. EPSS is trained on intrusion-detection and honeypot detections, so LEV estimates the probability of observed exploitation *activity*. KEV lists confirmed, actionable exploitation. Against sources closer to EPSS's own definition, LEV looks roughly twice too confident rather than eight times.

7 Threats to validity

We record 55 threats in the released repository. The ones that bear most on the conclusions:

- **Monthly sampling.** LEV's windows are 30 days and our snapshots are about 30.4 days apart. On 481 CVEs stratified by LEV decile, LEV from true daily windows differs from ours by 3.9% of mean LEV (population-weighted), with no consistent sign. The check covers the calibration cohort, not the older CVEs behind the CSWP 41 Table 5 rows.
- **Publication-date proxy.** We use first EPSS appearance as publication date, with a backfill filter. Without the filter, CSWP 41 Table 5's "all CVEs" row misses by 75%.
- **Circularity.** KEV is an EPSS input (Section 5.5), and Shadowserver is an EPSS label source. We measure the first and drop the second as a check; we cannot remove either from EPSS.
- **List dependence.** The log-linear model assumes no three-way interaction. We report estimates only where identified, and Table 4 shows how each configuration changes them.
- **Sparse cells.** In the middle stratum no CVE is on both CISA and SENSOR, and the unseen-cell estimate rests on 10 SENSOR-only CVEs; its interval (Table 3) is correspondingly wide. The correction curve is similarly imprecise at individual scores (Table 6).
- **VulnCheck precision.** VulnCheck supplies most single-list captures, and 65% of VulnCheck-only CVEs rest on one text report. The strict configuration keeps the top-stratum result; the middle-stratum estimate does not survive it.
- **Nested sources.** Two catalogues contain CISA KEV, and VulnCheck contains Shadowserver's list. Each was removed by source before modelling; a containment we did not detect would bias the estimates downward.
- **False sightings.** Telegram sightings include claims we cannot verify. Every headline figure is also given with that list excluded.
- **A short, young population.** SENSOR starts in October 2024, so Phase 2 covers CVEs first scored over 15 months, each observed for 6-21 months.
- **VulnCheck redistribution.** VulnCheck's terms do not say whether its data may be redistributed, so the snapshot is not in the released repository; reproducing the four-list results needs a free community token.
- **Normalization.** Percentile mapping removes corpus-wide shift and cannot separate it from genuine improvement in the newer model.
- **KEV dates.** `dateAdded` is a cataloguing date. Timing comparisons are lagged by an unknown amount.

- **Search scope.** Our search for prior work was targeted, not systematic.

8 Related work

EPSS and its evaluation. EPSS was introduced by Jacobs et al. [2] and extended with a larger feature set in version 3 [3]. Parla evaluates EPSS on high-severity CVEs in KEV [19]. These works evaluate the forward-looking score; none evaluates LEV.

LEV. Beyond the white paper [1], an independent reimplementation by the Risk Based Prioritization project questions LEV's small-probability approximation and its independence assumption, and disputes the white paper's reading of EPSS for previously exploited CVEs [20]. It does not validate LEV against exploitation data. LEV is already consumed downstream: Huang et al. use it, alongside EPSS and KEV, as an exposure probability for incident mitigation in cyber-physical systems [26]. We found no empirical evaluation of LEV in arXiv or the security literature up to September 2026.

Prioritization with KEV as ground truth. Recent frameworks combine CVSS, EPSS and KEV [21] or build composite risk indicators evaluated on KEV [22]. ThreatLens trains a ranking model on KEV entries as weak supervision [23]. Our results suggest caution with any of these: KEV is incomplete in a vendor-dependent way, and it is already an EPSS input. Shaffer and Voicu model exploitation hazard with a decay calibrated on KEV timing [24]; our cohorts show EPSS rising, not decaying, over 34 months.

Multiple-systems estimation. Capture-recapture over administrative lists is standard in epidemiology [12] and has been used to estimate casualties and modern slavery, where its sensitivity to list dependence and sparse cells is well documented [25]. We found no prior application to vulnerability exploitation.

9 Conclusion

Evaluated against KEV, LEV looks badly over-confident. Much of that is not LEV's doing. EPSS retraining puts an artifact into the product LEV computes, LEV accumulates without the saturation its design assumes, and KEV records a minority of the exploitation that other sources observe. Once that is accounted for, LEV over-predicts true exploitation by about 2-2.5x wherever the estimate can be made, rather than the 8x that KEV suggests. A monotone correction brings LEV's values in line with the broader ground truth and transfers a year ahead to CVEs it never saw, though it must be refitted as CVEs age.

The lowest LEV stratum, which holds most CVEs, remains out of reach of four lists. Its single-list captures come almost entirely from one source, so a fifth independent list with sensor coverage, such as GreyNoise's, is the natural next step.

10 Data and code availability

[Repository URL]. `make fetch` downloads the fixed inputs and `make reproduce` regenerates every table and figure. SHA-256 hashes, release tags and retrieval dates for all inputs are listed in `DATA_SNAPSHOT.md`.

References

See `references.md` for full entries and verification status.

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